

Call: HORIZON-MSCA-2025-PF
(MSCA Postdoctoral Fellowships 2025)

Topic: HORIZON-MSCA-2025-PF-01-01

Type of Action: HORIZON-TMA-MSCA-PF-EF
(HORIZON TMA MSCA Postdoctoral Fellowships - European Fellowships)

Proposal number: 101280152

Proposal acronym: ECO-CONNECT

Type of Model Grant Agreement: HORIZON Unit Grant

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1 - General information

Fields marked * are mandatory to fill.

Topic	HORIZON-MSCA-2025-PF-01-01	Type of Action	HORIZON-TMA-MSCA-PF-EF
Call	HORIZON-MSCA-2025-PF	Type of Model Grant Agreement	HORIZON-AG-UN

Acronym ECO-CONNECT

Proposal title Postcolonial Aesthetics and Ecological Interconnectedness in the Writings of Amitav Ghosh and Ben Okri

Note that for technical reasons, the following characters are not accepted in the Proposal Title and will be removed: < > " &

Scientific Area SOC - Social Sciences and Humanities (SOC)

Please select up to 5 descriptors (and at least 3) that best characterise the subject of your proposal, in descending order of relevance.

Descriptor 1 Cultural studies, cultural diversity

Descriptor 2 Comparative literature

Descriptor 3 Environment chemistry

Free keywords Comparative Literature, Climate Change Narratives, Ecocriticism, Environmental Humanities, Non-human Agencies, Postcolonial Literature

Please choose the scientific area and descriptors carefully, and in order of importance, since this will guide the REA in the selection of experts for proposal evaluation and the allocation of proposals to experts.

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Abstract *

ECO-CONNECT aims to explore how contemporary postcolonial literature represents ecological crisis and multispecies entanglements through the works of Amitav Ghosh and Ben Okri. The project examines how these authors articulate non-human agencies including animals, landscapes, climatic forces, and spiritual entities, and how they develop new aesthetics of interconnectedness that move beyond anthropocentrism. In doing so, ECO-CONNECT highlights the ways in which literature not only reflects but also reshapes human awareness of planetary interdependence.

By integrating postcolonial theory, ecocriticism, and posthumanist perspectives, the project introduces a novel interpretive framework that links cultural memory, ecological vulnerability, and multispecies ethics. This interdisciplinary approach foregrounds the contributions of Global South writers, whose narratives of displacement, colonial history, and environmental precarity provide vital insights into the global climate crisis. Through close comparative analysis of Ghosh and Okri, ECO-CONNECT reconceptualises the role of literature in addressing sustainability challenges, while also advancing dialogue between literary studies and environmental humanities.

The fellowship will be hosted at the University of Porto (FLUP, CITCEM), a centre of excellence in the humanities, where the researcher will benefit from advanced training, interdisciplinary mentoring, and integration into active research clusters. The project will generate scholarly outputs, including peer-reviewed articles, conference presentations, and contributions to teaching. It will also deliver wider societal benefits through public engagement, workshops, and open-access dissemination. By combining scientific excellence with cultural relevance, ECO-CONNECT will strengthen European leadership in sustainable humanities research, enhance the researcher's career perspectives, and position literary studies as a vital voice in global debates on climate change.

Remaining characters 2

Has this proposal (or a very similar one) been submitted in the past 2 years in response to a call for proposals under any EU programme, including the current call? ☐ Yes ☒ No

Please give the proposal reference or contract number.

Previously submitted proposals should be with either 6 or 9 digits.

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Declarations

Field(s) marked * are mandatory to fill.

1) We declare to have the explicit consent of all applicants on their participation and on the content of this proposal. * ☒

2) We confirm that the information contained in this proposal is correct and complete and that none of the project activities have started before the proposal was submitted (unless explicitly authorised in the call conditions). * ☒

3) We declare:

- to be fully compliant with the eligibility criteria set out in the call
- not to be subject to any exclusion grounds under the [EU Financial Regulation 2018/1046](#)
- to have the financial and operational capacity to carry out the proposed project. *

☒

4) We acknowledge that all communication will be made through the Funding & Tenders Portal electronic exchange system and that access and use of this system is subject to the [Funding & Tenders Portal Terms and Conditions](#). * ☒

5) We have read, understood and accepted the [Funding & Tenders Portal Terms & Conditions](#) and [Privacy Statement](#) that set out the conditions of use of the Portal and the scope, purposes, retention periods, etc. for the processing of personal data of all data subjects whose data we communicate for the purpose of the application, evaluation, award and subsequent management of our grant, prizes and contracts (including financial transactions and audits). * ☒

6) We declare that the proposal complies with ethical principles (including the highest standards of research integrity as set out in the [ALLEA European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity](#), as well as applicable international and national law, including the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union and the European Convention on Human Rights and its Supplementary Protocols. [Appropriate procedures, policies and structures](#) are in place to foster responsible research practices, to prevent questionable research practices and research misconduct, and to handle allegations of breaches of the principles and standards in the Code of Conduct. * ☒

7) We declare that the proposal has an exclusive focus on civil applications (activities intended to be used in military application or aiming to serve military purposes cannot be funded). If the project involves dual-use items in the sense of [Regulation 2021/821](#), or other items for which authorisation is required, we confirm that we will comply with the applicable regulatory framework (e.g. obtain export/import licences before these items are used). * ☒

8) We confirm that the activities proposed do not

- aim at human cloning for reproductive purposes;
- intend to modify the genetic heritage of human beings which could make such changes heritable (with the exception of research relating to cancer treatment of the gonads, which may be financed), or
- intend to create human embryos solely for the purpose of research or for the purpose of stem cell procurement, including by means of somatic cell nuclear transfer.
- lead to the destruction of human embryos (for example, for obtaining stem cells)

These activities are excluded from funding. * ☒

9) We confirm that for activities carried out outside the Union, the same activities would have been allowed in at least one EU Member State. * ☒

The coordinator is only responsible for the information relating to their own organisation. Each applicant remains responsible for the information declared for their organisation. If the proposal is retained for EU funding, they will all be required to sign a declaration of honour.

False statements or incorrect information may lead to administrative sanctions under the EU Financial Regulation.

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2 - Participants

List of participating organisations

#	Participating Organisation Legal Name	Country	Role	Action
1	UNIVERSIDADE DO PORTO	PT	Coordinator	

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Acronym **ECO-CONNECT**
Short name **U.PORTO**

Organisation data

PIC	Legal name
999894916	UNIVERSIDADE DO PORTO

Short name: U.PORTO

Address

Street PRACA GOMES TEIXEIRA
Town PORTO
Postcode 4099-002
Country Portugal
Webpage www.up.pt

Specific Legal Statuses

Legal person	yes	Academic Sector	yes
Public body	no		
Non-profit	yes		
International organisation	no		
Secondary or Higher education establishment	yes		
Research organisation	yes		

SME Data

Based on the below details from the Participant Registry the organisation is **not** an SME (small- and medium-sized enterprise) for the call.

SME self-declared status	03/07/2024 - no
SME self-assessment	12/05/2016 - no
SME validation	unknown

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Short name **U.PORTO**

Departments carrying out the proposed work

Department 1

Department name	FLUP	☐ not applicable
	☒ Same as proposing organisation's address	
Street	PRACA GOMES TEIXEIRA	
Town	PORTO	
Postcode	4099-002	
Country	Portugal	

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Short name **U.PORTO**

Supervisor

This will be the person the EU services will contact concerning this proposal (e.g. for additional information, invitation to hearings, sending of evaluation results, convocation to start grant preparation). The data in blue is read-only. Details (name, first name and e-mail) of Main Contact persons should be edited in the step "Participants" of the submission wizard.

Title **Dr**

Gender ☐ Woman ☒ Man ☐ Non Binary

First name* **Francisco**

Last name* **Topa**

E-Mail* **ftopa@letras.up.pt**

Position in org. **Professor of African Literatures Faculty of Arts and Humanities**

Department **UNIVERSIDADE DO PORTO**

☒ Same as organisation name

☒ Same as proposing organisation's address

Street **PRACA GOMES TEIXEIRA**

Town **PORTO** Post code **4099-002**

Country **Portugal**

Website **https://www.up.pt/portal/en/**

Phone **351 226077100** Phone 2 **+xxx xxxxxxxxx**

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Short name **U.PORTO**

Researcher

The name and e-mail of the Researcher and Supervisor are read-only in the administrative form, only additional details can be edited here. To give access rights and contact details of contact persons, please go back to Participant's page of the submission wizard and save the changes.

Last Name*	Ahmed	Last Name at Birth	Ahmed
First Name(s)*	Huma	Gender*	☒ Woman ☐ Man ☐ Non binary
Title	Mrs	Country of residence*	Pakistan
Nationality*	Pakistan	Nationality 2	
Date of Birth (DD/MM/YYYY)	26/12/1984	Country of Birth*	Pakistan
		Place of Birth	Lahore (Pakistan)

Contact address

Current organisation name	The University of Lahore		
Current Department/Faculty/Institute/Laboratory name	Department of English Language and Literature		
	☐ Same as organisation address		
Street	209 1-C-1 Township Lahore		
Postcode/Cedex	54000	Town	Township
Phone	+923214175547	Country	Pakistan
Phone2 / Mobile	+923074900502		
E-Mail*	humanaz096@gmail.com		
ORCID	0009-0000-1927-5870		
Researcher ID			
	The maximum length of the identifier is 11 characters (ZZZ-9999-2010) and the minimum length is 9 characters (A-1001-2010).		
Other ID	Please enter the type of ID here		Please enter the identifier number here

Qualifications

Doctorate Date of (expected) award	Select the exact date (DD/MM/YYYY)	07/07/2025
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Short name **U.PORTO**

Place of activity/place of residence (previous 5 years - most recent one first)

Indicate the period(s) and the country/countries in which you have legally resided and/or had your main activity (work, studies, etc) during the last 5 years up until the deadline for the submission of the proposal.

Please fill in this section without gaps. Short stays (as defined in the Guide for Applicants) shall not be listed in this box.

Period from	Period to	Duration (days)	Country
11/09/2019	10/09/2025	2192	Pakistan
Total		2192	

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Role of participating organisation in the project

Project management	☒
Communication, dissemination and engagement	☒
Provision of research and technology infrastructure	☒
Co-definition of research and market needs	☒
Civil society representative	☒
Policy maker or regulator, incl. standardisation body	☒
Research performer	☒
Technology developer	☒
Testing/validation of approaches and ideas	☒
Prototyping and demonstration	☒
IPR management incl. technology transfer	☒
Public procurer of results	☒
Private buyer of results	☒
Finance provider (public or private)	☐
Education and training	☒
Contributions from the social sciences or/and the humanities	☐
Other If yes, please specify: (Maximum number of characters allowed: 50)	☐

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List of up to 5 publications, widely-used datasets, software, goods, services, or any other achievements relevant to the call content.

Type of achievement	Short description (Max 500 characters)

List of up to 5 most relevant previous projects or activities, connected to the subject of this proposal.

Name of Project or Activity	Short description (Max 500 characters)

Description of any significant infrastructure and/or any major items of technical equipment, relevant to the proposed work.

Name of infrastructure of equipment	Short description (Max 300 characters)

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Gender Equality Plan

Does the organization have a Gender Equality Plan (GEP) covering the elements listed below?

☒ Yes ☐ No

Minimum process-related requirements (building blocks) for a GEP

- **Publication:** formal document published on the institution's website and signed by the top management
- **Dedicated resources:** commitment of human resources and gender expertise to implement it.
- **Data collection and monitoring:** sex/gender disaggregated data on personnel (and students for establishments concerned) and annual reporting based on indicators.
- **Training:** Awareness raising/trainings on gender equality and unconscious gender biases for staff and decision-makers.
- **Content-wise, recommended areas to be covered** and addressed via concrete measures and targets are:
 - o work-life balance and organisational culture;
 - o gender balance in leadership and decision-making;
 - o gender equality in recruitment and career progression;
 - o integration of the gender dimension into research and teaching content;
 - o measures against gender-based violence including sexual harassment.

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3 - Budget

Is the Researcher eligible for family allowance?* ☒ Yes ☐ No

Duration of fellowship *	Country in which fellowship will take place
24	Portugal

	Country Coefficient	Number of Months	Contributions for recruited researchers			Institutional contributions		Total
			Living Allowance	Mobility Allowance	Family Allowance	Research, training and networking costs	Management and indirect costs	
Fellowship	0.937	24	134703.12	17040.00	15840.00	24000.00	15600.00	207183.12
Total			134703.12	17040.00	15840.00	24000.00	15600.00	207183.12

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4 - Ethics & security

Ethics Issues Table

1. Human Embryonic Stem Cells and Human Embryos		Page
Does this activity involve Human Embryonic Stem Cells (hESCs)?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve the use of human embryos?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
2. Humans		Page
Does this activity involve human participants?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve interventions (physical also including imaging technology, behavioural treatments, etc.) on the study participants?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve conducting a clinical study as defined by the Clinical Trial Regulation (EU 536/2014) ? (using pharmaceuticals, biologicals, radiopharmaceuticals, or advanced therapy medicinal products)	☐ Yes ☒ No	
3. Human Cells / Tissues (not covered by section 1)		Page
Does this activity involve the use of human cells or tissues?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
4. Personal Data		Page
Does this activity involve processing of personal data?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve further processing of previously collected personal data (including use of preexisting data sets or sources, merging existing data sets)?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Is it planned to export personal data from the EU to non-EU countries?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Is it planned to import personal data from non-EU countries into the EU or from a non-EU country to another non-EU country?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve the processing of personal data related to criminal convictions or offences?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
5. Animals		Page
Does this activity involve animals?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
6. Non-EU Countries		Page
Will some of the activities be carried out in non-EU countries?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
In case non-EU countries are involved, do the activities undertaken in these countries raise potential ethics issues?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
It is planned to use local resources (e.g. animal and/or human tissue samples, genetic material, live animals, human remains, materials of historical value, endangered fauna or flora samples, etc.)?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Is it planned to import any material (other than data) from non-EU countries into the EU or from a non-EU country to another non-EU country? For data imports, see section 4.	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Is it planned to export any material (other than data) from the EU to non-EU countries? For data exports, see section 4.	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve low and/or lower middle income countries , (if yes, detail the benefit-sharing actions planned in the self-assessment)	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Could the situation in the country put the individuals taking part in the activity at risk?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
7. Environment, Health and Safety		Page

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Does this activity involve the use of substances or processes that may cause harm to the environment, to animals or plants.(during the implementation of the activity or further to the use of the results, as a possible impact) ? ☐ Yes ☒ No

Does this activity deal with endangered fauna and/or flora / protected areas? ☐ Yes ☒ No

Does this activity involve the use of substances or processes that may cause harm to humans, including those performing the activity.(during the implementation of the activity or further to the use of the results, as a possible impact) ? ☐ Yes ☒ No

8. Artificial Intelligence

Page

Does this activity involve the development, deployment and/or use of Artificial Intelligence-based systems? ☐ Yes ☒ No

9. Other Ethics Issues

Page

Are there any other ethics issues that should be taken into consideration? ☐ Yes ☒ No

I confirm that I have taken into account all ethics issues above and that, if any ethics issues apply, I will complete the ethics self-assessment as described in the guidelines [How to Complete your Ethics Self-Assessment](#)



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Ethics Self-Assessment

Ethical dimension of the objectives, methodology and likely impact

Explain in detail the identified issues in relation to:

- objectives of the activities (e.g. study of vulnerable populations, etc.)
- methodology (e.g. clinical trials, involvement of children, protection of personal data, etc.)
- the potential impact of the activities (e.g. environmental damage, stigmatisation of particular social groups, political or financial adverse consequences, misuse, etc.)

Remaining characters

5000

Compliance with ethical principles and relevant legislations

Describe how the issue(s) identified in the ethics issues table above will be addressed in order to adhere to the ethical principles and what will be done to ensure that the activities are compliant with the EU/national legal and ethical requirements of the country or countries where the tasks are to be carried out. It is reminded that for activities performed in a non-EU countries, they should also be allowed in at least one EU Member State.

Remaining characters

5000

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Security issues table

1. EU Classified Information (EUCI) ²		Page
Does this activity involve information and/or materials requiring protection against unauthorised disclosure (EUCI)?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Does this activity involve non-EU countries which need to have access to EUCI?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
2. Misuse		Page
Does this activity have the potential for misuse of results?	☐ Yes ☒ No	
3. Other Security Issues		Page
Does this activity involve information and/or materials subject to national security restrictions? If yes, please specify: (Maximum number of characters allowed: 1000)	☐ Yes ☒ No	
Are there any other security issues that should be taken into consideration? If yes, please specify: (Maximum number of characters allowed: 1000)	☐ Yes ☒ No	

Security self-assessment

Please specify: (Maximum number of characters allowed: 5000)

Remaining characters 5000

²According to the Commission Decision (EU, Euratom) 2015/444 of 13 March 2015 on the security rules for protecting EU classified information, “European Union classified information (EUCI) means any information or material designated by an EU security classification, the unauthorised disclosure of which could cause varying degrees of prejudice to the interests of the European Union or of one or more of the Member States”.

³Classified background information is information that is already classified by a country and/or international organisation and/or the EU and is going to be used by the project. In this case, the project must have in advance the authorisation from the originator of the classified information, which is the entity (EU institution, EU Member State, third state or international organisation) under whose authority the classified information has been generated.

⁴EU classified foreground information is information (documents/deliverables/materials) planned to be generated by the project and that needs to be protected from unauthorised disclosure. The originator of the EUCI generated by the project is the European Commission.

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5 - Other questions

Information on the Researcher (future fellow)

1. Were you in the last 3 years in compulsory national service? ☐ Yes ☒ No

2. Did you spend time, in the last 3 years, on procedures for obtaining refugee status (according to the 1951 Geneva Refugee Convention and the 1967 Protocol) in a Member State or Associated Country to Horizon Europe? ☐ Yes ☒ No

3. Are you a national of a Member State or Associated Country? ☐ Yes ☒ No

Are you a long term resident of a Member State or Associated Country? ☐ Yes ☒ No

Other Questions

4. Do you wish to participate to the ERA Postdoctoral Fellowships and thus increase your chances of being funded? ☒ Yes ☐ No

If you don't reply or if you maintain 'No' as your answer, be aware that your proposal will not benefit from an extra chance of being funded under the ERA Postdoctoral Fellowships in case it cannot be funded under the MSCA Postdoctoral Fellowships (MSCA-PF).

A dedicated budget from the Work Programme "Widening participation and strengthening the European Research Area" has been set aside to fund those proposals.

European Postdoctoral Fellowships proposals where the host organisation is located in an eligible widening country (according to the PIC number) but were not funded under MSCA-PF call due to a lack of budget, can be automatically duplicated into the ERA Postdoctoral Fellowships call.

Eligible proposals will be duplicated into the ERA Postdoctoral Fellowships call only if you express your wish to do so.

Your decision not to participate in the ERA Postdoctoral Fellowships will not affect your chances of being funded directly under the MSCA-PF call.

5. Are the research and training activities proposed addressing topics related to nuclear sciences and technology, as outlined in the Guide for applicants for this call and the Euratom Research and Training Programme (ERTP)? ** ☐ Yes ☒ No

Answer "Yes" ONLY IF all three conditions below are fulfilled:

- The proposal's research area is covered by the ERTTP
- The host organisation (and, if applicable, the Associated Partner for the additional Placement period) is/are established in a Member State or Associated Country to the ERTTP
- The researcher is a national or a long-term resident of a Member State or Associated Country to the ERTTP

6. For communication purposes only, the European Commission REA asks for permission to publish the name of the researcher (future fellow) should the proposal be retained for funding. Does the researcher (future fellow) give this permission? ☒ Yes ☐ No

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7. Some national and regional public research funding authorities run schemes to fund MSCA applicants that score highly in the MSCA evaluation but which cannot be funded by the MSCA due to their limited budget. In case this proposal could not be selected for funding by the MSCA, do the researcher and supervisor consent to the European Commission disclosing to such authorities the results of its evaluation (score and ranking range) together with their names and contact details, non-confidential proposal title and abstract, proposal acronym, and host organisation? ☒ Yes ☐ No

PART B

[This document is tagged. Do not delete the tags; they are needed for processing.] #@APP-FORM-HEMSCAPF@#

Part B-1

1. Excellence #@REL-EVA-RE@#

1.1 *Quality and pertinence of the project's research and innovation objectives (and the extent to which they are ambitious, and go beyond the state of the art)*

R&I objectives include:

- To formulate "eco-postcolonial aesthetics" by the critical integration of posthumanism, ecocriticism, and postcolonial theory in literary analysis. This helps contribute original theoretical stance by bridging the gap between environmental ethics and literary studies.
- To examine the aesthetic, symbolic, and political roles played by non-human agencies (rivers, animals, spirits, and landscapes) in selected fiction of Ghosh and Okri. This calls into question anthropocentric interpretations and highlights how literature can depict entanglements between multiple species.
- To explore how postcolonial fiction reconfigures cultural understanding of nature, place, and belonging in the context of displacement, and ecological crisis. The project situates literary texts as tools for understanding and communicating planetary interconnectedness.
- To develop a comparative framework for multidisciplinary literary studies that may be applied to environmental cultural studies and postcolonial literatures. The framework's adaptability to different authors, geographical areas, and study situations is what makes it innovative.
- To engage broader audiences in sustainability discourse through publications, talks, blogs, and creative public events in collaboration with cultural organizations and educational institutions.
- The project will generate impact beyond academia by translating complex ideas into public narratives of responsibility and care.

The project goes beyond the current state of art by:

- Introducing the concept of eco-postcolonial aesthetic which draws from posthumanism, multispecies ethnography and postcolonial theory to analyse how non-human life forms participate in narrative meaning making.
- Undertaking the first comparative study of Amitav Ghosh and Ben Okri that specifically focuses on their treatment of non-human agencies and ecological imaginaries.
- Challenging prevailing anthropocentric frameworks by foregrounding ontological plurality, planetary interconnectedness and the agency of more-than-human worlds
- Bridging the literary with the ethical and political by framing these texts as cultural inventions in climate discourse. It makes literature a key participant in the environmental humanities.

The project is ambitious in its:

- Theoretical synthesis across disciplines (postcolonial studies, ecocriticism and posthumanism).
- Aim to redefine modes of reading postcolonial literature through ecological perspectives
- Commitment to public-facing impact by translating research findings into community-oriented events, blogs, and educational materials.

1.2 *Soundness of the proposed methodology (including interdisciplinary approaches, consideration of the gender dimension and other diversity aspects if relevant for the research project, and the quality of open science practices).*

Overall methodology

ECO-CONNECT employs a qualitative, text-based methodology rooted in close reading, comparative literary analysis, and critical theory. It applies an interdisciplinary lens—postcolonial theory, ecocriticism, and posthumanism. It helps analyze how Amitav Ghosh and Ben Okri represent non-human agencies (animals, landscapes, elements, spiritual forces) and articulate planetary interdependence.

Integration of methods and disciplines to pursue the objectives: The project is interdisciplinary by nature and lies at the nexus of:

- Postcolonial Studies (narratives of identity, displacement, and empire)
- Environmental Humanities (ecological ethics, climate change)
- Posthumanist Theory (de-centering the human subject, non-human agency)

This synthesis enables a novel interpretive model that reconceptualizes literary agency, environment, and relationality. While literary analysis forms the foundation, the interdisciplinary approach enriches interpretation and expands the societal and academic impact of the research.

- Workshops and mentoring sessions at U.PORTO and CITCEM will support integration, offering access to both humanities and ecological research communities. The methodology also benefits from a comparative dimension (Indian and African authors) that supports transregional analysis.

Gender dimension and other diversity aspects: The writings under investigation highlight the intersections of gender, race, and ecological fragility, frequently illustrating how marginalised groups, including women, are disproportionately impacted by environmental deterioration. Even when gender is not the main focus, the project uses feminist ecocriticism and intersectional analysis to highlight inclusivity. This aligns with Horizon Europe's commitment to diversity-sensitive research content.

Open science practices

The project ensures transparency and accessibility through open science:

- **Open Access:** All publications will be available via gold or green routes (U.PORTO's Repositório Aberto, Zenodo).

- **FAIR outputs:** Non-sensitive materials (bibliographies, thematic mappings, conceptual frameworks, analysis notes) will be shared with proper metadata.
- **Data Management Plan (Month 6):** Outlining data types, access/storage mechanisms, licensing (Creative Commons), and long-term preservation.
- **Reproducibility:** Analytical categories, theoretical models, and schematics will be documented and shared via preprints and open platforms.

This approach ensures the responsible and collaborative generation of knowledge in line with Horizon Europe's open science policy.

1.3 Quality of the supervision, training and of the two-way transfer of knowledge between the researcher and the host

Prof. Francisco Topa, Associate Professor with *Agregação*, is an integrated member of CITCEM, head of the Department of Portuguese and Romance Studies, and Chair of the Agostinho Neto programme at FLUP. He has authored 260 works (29 books), teaches African Literatures, and has extensive PhD and postdoctoral supervision experience.

Planned training for the researcher

1. **Scientific & methodological:** Advanced workshops in postcolonial theory, ecocriticism, posthumanism; training in archival research, digital humanities, and academic publishing.
2. **Research management & organisation:** Hands-on experience in organising conferences/panels, project management, budgeting, funding applications, and ethics compliance.
3. **Horizontal & transferable skills:** Communication and outreach (blogs, public lectures), open science/data management, and career development via U.PORTO's training services.

Two-way transfer of knowledge (European Fellowship)

- **From host to researcher:** Access to CITCEM's interdisciplinary environment, advanced methodological expertise, and international research networks.
- **From researcher to host:** CITCEM's thematic lines, the introduction of novel frameworks for examining non-human agency in postcolonial literature, and the enhancement of FLUP's curriculum through mentoring, lectures, and seminars.

Secondments/placements

No formal secondment is planned. Informal collaborations with Portuguese cultural institutions, literary festivals, and NGOs on environmental awareness will enhance the project's societal impact.

1.4 Quality and appropriateness of the researcher's professional experience, competences and skills

In addition to having a PhD in English literature (postcolonial studies, comparative literature), the researcher has an extensive background of expertise in teaching, research, and publishing.

2. Impact #@IMP-ACT-IA@#

2.1 Credibility of the measures to enhance the career perspectives and employability of the researcher and contribution to his/her skills development

Career Perspectives and Employability

The ECO-CONNECT fellowship will significantly enhance the researcher's career prospects within academia and beyond by:

- Providing advanced interdisciplinary training in postcolonial, ecological, and posthumanist literary studies, strengthening competitiveness in the global academic job market.
- Building international collaborations through U.PORTO's partnerships in Europe, Africa, and Latin America, widening career opportunities in transnational contexts.
- Developing expertise in open science, data management, and dissemination, essential for research-intensive careers and competitive funding applications (ERC, FCT, Horizon Europe).
- Equipping the researcher with transferable skills (project management, event organization, and research communication) valued by academia, cultural institutions, NGOs, and policy organizations.

Skills Development Contribution

- **Scientific excellence:** Specialist expertise in eco-postcolonial humanities.
- **Research management:** Capacity to design, lead, and disseminate projects.
- **Transversal skills:** Enhanced teaching, mentoring, and communication abilities.
- **International profile:** Broader visibility through conferences, networks, and publications.

Long-term alignment

The fellowship supports the researcher's goal of securing a tenure-track academic position in English and Comparative Literature while also enabling flexible career pathways in cultural, NGO, or policy sectors linked to sustainability and heritage.

2.2 Suitability and Quality of Dissemination, Exploitation, and Communication Measures

Dissemination

- 2–3 open-access journal articles in leading international journals (*e.g.*, *Interventions*, *Environmental Humanities*).
- Presentations at major conferences (ESSE, EACLALS, ASLE) and U.PORTO seminars.
- Contributions to edited volumes and deposit of outputs in open repositories (Repositório Aberto, Zenodo).

Exploitation

- Integration of findings into U.PORTO postgraduate teaching.

- Use of ECO-CONNECT’s comparative framework as a teaching and research resource.
- Collaboration with NGOs and cultural organisations for awareness initiatives linking literature and climate change.

Communication & Public Engagement

- **General public:** Public lectures, literary festivals, blog series “*Stories of Interconnection*”, social media outreach.
- **Students:** School/university workshops and podcasts on “Literature and Climate Change.”
- **Policy & NGOs:** Policy briefs and collaborations on sustainability communication.
- **Scientific community:** Network engagement (ASLE, EACLALS) and open methodologies.

Main messages

- Literature helps reframe ecological crisis and human–non-human relationships.
- Postcolonial perspectives ensure inclusive, global climate narratives.
- Humanities research contributes cultural insights to debates on sustainability.

IPR and knowledge management

- Outputs protected via copyright; shared under Creative Commons (CC BY 4.0) when possible.
- No patents foreseen; publications comply with Horizon Europe open-access mandates.

Proportionality

Measures are strategic, realistic, and balanced: ensuring academic excellence, societal engagement, and long-term reuse of results.

2.3 Magnitude and Importance of Expected Impacts

Scientific impact

- Introduces a novel eco-postcolonial framework, bridging postcolonial studies, environmental humanities, and post humanism.
- Expands tools for analyzing literature’s role in framing ecological crisis.
- Ensures broad academic uptake through open-access publications and international dissemination.

Societal impact

- Engages with urgent global issues—climate change, inequality, and sustainability through cultural narratives.
- Raises ecological awareness among citizens, schools, and NGOs via lectures, workshops, and outreach.
- Contributes to European cultural diplomacy by foregrounding Global South perspectives in sustainability debates.

Economic and career impact

- Increases the researcher's competitiveness and employability.
- Generates transferable skills that are useful in NGOs, the creative industries, and academics.
- Guarantees that educators and members of civil society can freely reuse the products (frameworks, annotated bibliographies, and analytical notes).

Magnitude and significance

Academically: enhances Europe's position as a leader in the multidisciplinary humanities.

Socially: adds cultural perspectives to discussions about sustainability and climate change.

- Professionally: ensures a sustained contribution to the body of knowledge in Europe by integrating the researcher's career.

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3. Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation #@QUA-LIT-QL@# #@WRK-PLA-WP@# #@CON-SOR-CS@# #@PRJ-MGT-PM@#

3.1 *Quality and effectiveness of the work plan, assessment of risks and appropriateness of the effort assigned to work packages*

Overall Work Plan Structure

The ECO-CONNECT project will run for 24 months, organized into three interlinked Work Packages (WPs) to ensure clarity, efficiency, and coherence:

- **WP1 – Literature Review, Theoretical Framework, and Training (Months 1–6)**
- **WP2 – Research, Analysis, and Writing (Months 7–18)**
- **WP3 – Dissemination, Communication, and Career Development (Months 19–24)**

Each WP contains clear deliverables (outputs) and milestones (checkpoints). The effort assigned is balanced, ensuring adequate time for research, writing, and dissemination.

Work Packages, Deliverables, and Milestones

WP1 – Literature Review, Theoretical Framework, and Training (M1–M6)

- Activities: Establish conceptual framework; complete advanced training (CITCEM seminars, transferable skills workshops); refine methodology.
- Deliverables: D1.1 Annotated bibliography; D1.2 Project methodology outline.
- Milestone: MS1 – Theoretical framework finalized (M6).

WP2 – Research, Analysis, and Writing (M7–M18)

- Activities: Conduct textual analysis of Ghosh and Okri; integrate postcolonial and ecological approaches; draft journal articles.
- Deliverables: D2.1 Draft of first article; D2.2 Draft of second article/book chapter.
- Milestones: MS2 – First article submitted (M12); MS3 – Second article submitted (M18).

WP3 – Dissemination, Communication, and Career Development (M19–M24)

- Activities: Present results at international conferences; publish in open-access journals; lead public outreach (lectures, blogs, and schools); finalize Data Management Plan.
- Deliverables: D3.1 Two peer-reviewed publications; D3.2 Final dissemination report; D3.3 Career development portfolio.
- Milestone: MS4 – International conference presentation (M20); MS5 – Project completion and final report (M24).

Risk Assessment and Mitigation

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation Measures
Delay in publication acceptance	Medium	Medium	Target multiple journals simultaneously; prepare pre-prints for repository upload.
Limited access to relevant research materials	Low	Medium	Use interlibrary loans, digital repositories, and supervisor's networks.
Travel or conference disruptions (e.g. pandemic)	Medium	Low	Use virtual conferences and digital dissemination.
Research scope too broad	Medium	High	Supervisor guidance and periodic review meetings to keep

			focus manageable.
Administrative delays (e.g. visa, contracts)	Low	Low	Early coordination with U.PORTO administrative offices.

These mechanisms ensure that the project remains feasible, flexible, and able to deliver results on time.

3.2 Quality and capacity of the host institutions and participating organisations, including hosting arrangements

Hosting Arrangements

The fellowship will be hosted at the Faculty of Arts and Humanities of the University Of Porto (FLUP), with research activities conducted in close collaboration with the Transdisciplinary Research Centre for Culture, Space and Memory (CITCEM). The researcher will be fully integrated into the CITCEM research cluster “Culture and Environment”, directly aligning with the project’s thematic focus on postcolonial and ecological humanities.

A personalized supervision and mentoring plan will be implemented, including:

- Regular meetings with the main supervisor for close academic guidance.
- Participation in research seminars, workshops, and advanced training sessions offered by FLUP and CITCEM.
- Access to FLUP’s Career Development Office, library services, international relations office, and IT support, ensuring smooth administrative and professional integration.

The host institution will provide a dedicated workspace, IT facilities, and access to UPORTO’s digital learning and research platforms. The fellow will also be encouraged to take part in teaching, mentoring, and public engagement activities, ensuring both academic and societal integration.

Quality and Capacity of the Host Institution

The University of Porto is one of Portugal’s top research-intensive universities, consistently ranked among the top 300 universities worldwide. FLUP, as one of its largest faculties, is a hub for research in humanities and social sciences.

CITCEM (Transdisciplinary Research Centre for Culture, Space and Memory):

- Funded by the Portuguese Science and Technology Foundation (FCT), rated Very Good.
- Comprises over 400 integrated and collaborating researchers across disciplines including history, literature, cultural studies, environmental humanities, and heritage studies.
- Provides a dynamic, interdisciplinary environment, making it an ideal host for a project addressing postcolonial aesthetics, multispecies sensibilities, and ecological thought.

- Strong record of hosting and mentoring postdoctoral fellows and PhD students from across Europe and beyond.

Research Infrastructure and Facilities

- FLUP and CITCEM offer state-of-the-art research infrastructure, including access to UPORTO's central and specialized libraries (one of the largest academic library systems in Portugal), digital databases, archival resources, and IT equipment.
- Facilities for seminars, conferences, and hybrid events (on-site + online), supporting both academic and outreach activities.
- Access to international mobility networks through UPORTO's partnerships in Europe, Africa, and Latin America.
- Administrative and financial management support for MSCA projects, ensuring smooth project execution.

Integration into the Research Environment

The fellow will be integrated not only into CITCEM but also into the wider academic community of FLUP, benefiting from:

- Interdisciplinary collaboration opportunities with scholars in literary studies, environmental humanities, history, and cultural memory.
- Participation in doctoral and postdoctoral training programs, enhancing academic development.
- Engagement with UPORTO's internationalization strategy, which promotes researcher mobility, joint publications, and network-building.

Capacity of Participating Organization

This fellowship will be hosted solely by the University of Porto (FLUP / CITCEM). No additional participating organizations or secondments are foreseen at this stage. However, the host's international research networks and collaborations will enable the fellow to engage with external partners, ensuring strong academic visibility and knowledge exchange.

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Part B-2
(No overall page limit applied)

4. CV of the researcher

Name: Huma Ahmed

Email: humanaz096@gmail.com | Phone: +92 321 4175547

ORCID / Profile: <https://orcid.org/0009-0000-1927-5870>

Current Position: Assistant Professor of English, University of Lahore

Education

Ph.D. in English Literature, Lincoln University College Malaysia (2021–2024)

M.Phil. in English Literature, Minhaj University Lahore (2014–2016)

Professional Experience

Assistant Professor of English – University of Lahore, Pakistan (2017–present)

- Teaching BA, MA, MPhil, and PhD courses in Postcolonial Literature, Women's Literature, Literary Theory, Romantic Poetry, Modern Drama, Victorian Novel, Academic Writing.

- Supervised 10+ MA/MPhil theses to completion.

Lecturer in English – Lahore Garrison University (2016–2017)

Visiting Lecturer – Minhaj University Lahore (2017)

Research Interests

- Postcolonial Theory and Literature
- Feminist Literary Studies
- Ecocriticism and Post humanism
- Aesthetic Criticism and Comparative Literature

Publications (Selected, peer-reviewed)

- Locating Postcolonial Literary Aesthetic in Transcultural Contact Zone: A Politico-aesthetic Analysis of Hanif Kureishi's Short Stories, Int. Journal of Literary Humanities (2024).
- Formulation and Reformulation of Postcolonial Poetics: Ben Okri's Comic Destiny, Int. Journal of Literary Humanities (2024).
- Epistemology and Silence in Hanif Kureishi's Short Stories, Int. Journal of Business and Economic Affairs (2024).
- Postcolonial Aesthetic Concerns in James Joyce's Dubliners, Journal of Management Practices, Humanities & Social Sciences (2024).
- Nationalism in Joyce's Finnegans Wake: A Politico-Aesthetic Study, IJBEA (2024).
- Appropriation of Western Culture in South-Asian Media, Multicultural Education (2022).
- Deleuze's Transcendental Empiricism and Iqbal's Khudi, Univ. of Chitral JLL (2022).
- Meaning-Making and Aesthetic Response in Sylvia Plath's Poetry, JMPHSS (2022).

- Responses to Modernity in Elif Shafak's Works, Univ. of Chitral JLL (2021).
- Global Impact of Western Superstructures during COVID-19, The Dialogue (2021).

Conference Presentations (Selected)

- Session Chair & Presenter, 2nd Int. Conf. on Linguistics, Literary & Pedagogical Turns, Pakistan (2022).
- Presenter, 5th Int. Interdisciplinary Conference on Memory and Forgetting, Poland (2022, online).
- Co-presenter, 4th World Conf. on Research in Social Sciences, Norway (2022).
- Presenter, 1st Int. Conf. on Advances in English Language, Literature and Linguistics, Pakistan (2021).

Supervision & Teaching

- Supervised multiple MA/MPhil theses in postcolonial studies, feminist theory, and literary criticism.
- Designed and taught undergraduate/postgraduate modules on Postcolonial Literature, Women's Writing, Romantic Poetry, Classical Drama, Literary Movements, and Academic Writing Skills

Skills & Competences

- Curriculum design and academic planning
- Advanced academic writing and publication
- Research project supervision
- Conference organization and presentation
- Open Science practices and dissemination
- Student counseling and engagement

5. Capacity of the Participating Organization(s)

5.1 Template table: Overview of Participating Organisations

Organisation role	PIC	Legal Entity Short Name	Academic organisation (Y/N)	Country	Name of Supervisor
Beneficiary					
Associated partner linked to a beneficiary (if applicable)	999894 916	UPORTO	yes	Portugal	Francisco Topa
Associated partner for outgoing phase (mandatory for GF)	Not applicable				

Associated partner for secondment (if applicable)	Not applicable				
Associated partner for non-academic placement (if applicable)	Not applicable				

5.2 Template table: *Capacity of the Participating Organisations*

Maximum 1 page for the Beneficiary and ½ page per Associated partner.

Choose one of: ? Beneficiary (UPORTO) ? Associated partner linked to a beneficiary (if applicable) ? Associated partner for outgoing phase (mandatory for GF only) ? Associated partner for secondment (if applicable) ? Associated partner for non-academic placement (if applicable)	
[Full name + Legal Entity Short Name + Country] Universidade do Porto, UPORTO, Portugal	
General description	The University of Porto (UPORTO) is a leading R&I institution in Portugal with over 100 years of history. It is the largest producer of science in the country, responsible for nearly 25% of Portuguese ISI Web of Science articles. UPORTO hosts 35,000 students and 5,300 staff across 14 faculties and a business school. 2. Research and Innovation Excellence: • Research Units: UPORTO houses 48 research centres, 90% of which are rated "Excellent" or "Very Good" by the Portuguese Foundation for Science and Technology (FCT). • Infrastructure: The University is integrated into a vast research ecosystem including 17 Associated Laboratories, 22 Collaborative Labs, 11 Associated Research Institutes, and 24 national research infrastructures. • EU Funding Track Record: UPORTO has significant experience in EU frameworks, participating in 31 MSCA projects under H2020 (19 ITN, 8 RISE, 3 IF, 1 NIGHT) and is currently involved in 18 MSCA projects under Horizon Europe (2 PF, 14 DN, 2 SE). • European Alliances: UPORTO is a founding member of the EUGLOH (European University Alliance for Global Health) Erasmus+ initiative. 3. Specific Details for the Faculty of Arts and Humanities (FLUP): • Academic Scope: FLUP is a large faculty within UPORTO with ~4,500 students, offering 13 undergraduates, 29 masters, and 10 doctoral programs in Social Sciences, Humanities, and

	Arts. • Research Capacity: The faculty hosts 8 FCT-funded research centres and its staff are highly active in research, with vast scientific output and international experience. FLUP is currently involved in 39 national and 2 international projects. • MSCA Experience: FLUP has direct, relevant experience as a successful host in MSCA schemes: ○ Participated in a MSCA EJD (MOVES). ○ Successfully hosted two MSCA Postdoctoral Fellowships (PF). • Supervisory Environment: The proposed supervisor will be an experienced academic from FLUP's staff of 200 teachers and 34 researchers, ensuring excellent guidance within a dynamic research environment that strongly values the articulation between research and education.
Role and profile of supervisor	Prof. Topa is an internationally recognized scholar in African and Lusophone literatures, with over 260 publications, including 29 books, and current Head of the Department of Portuguese and Romance Studies. He holds the Agostinho Neto Chair and has extensive experience supervising PhD and postdoctoral researchers. His role in ECO-CONNECT is to provide intellectual and methodological guidance, facilitate integration into CITCEM's research clusters ("Culture and Environment", "Cultural Landscapes"), and mentor the fellow in academic writing, dissemination, and career development. He will also ensure effective two-way knowledge transfer, drawing on his international collaborations and networks to enhance the project's scholarly visibility and the fellow's career prospects.
Key research facilities, Infrastructure and Equipment	Through [R&D]-FLUP, researchers have access to an extensive collection of resources. FLUP is well equipped with essential infrastructures, including classrooms, computer rooms, lecture halls, offices for faculty staff and services, a map library and the Faculty's Central Library, which holds close to 500.000 volumes (available in its digital catalogue) also offers a range of specialized international databases, including a variety of electronic publications and journals, which provide access to a wealth of relevant national and international journals across the social sciences, as well as data archives from national and international sources. FLUP also has the Centre for Cultural Studies in Portugal - Casa dos Livros, where it has collections of the greatest socio-cultural relevance. In addition, [R&D]-FLUP, ensures suitable working conditions, including individual working stations and complementary facilities, and supports engaging events and opportunities to communicate and transfer scientific knowledge.

Previous and current involvement in EU-funded research and training programmes/actions/projects

COMPLETED PROJECT

Reference:

Grant agreement ID: 812764

Acronym:

DMOVES

Date:

2019 - 2022

Financing Entities:

Marie Skłodowska-Curie Action

Resources:

<http://projectmoves.eu/>

+info: <https://cordis.europa.eu/project/id/812764>

Promoter(s): FLUP, CITCEM, CETAPS, CNRS, IRCL, Charles University, Freie Universität Berlin, Université Paul-Valéry – Montpellier III, University of Kent, Univerzita Karlova

CURRENTLY PARTICIPATING

https://sigarra.up.pt/flup/pt/projectos_geral.mostra_projecto?P_ID=8349

Breaking the Code: Algorithmic Non-Normativity in Creative Digital Humanities

Programme DARIAH - DARIAH Theme Call

Funding Institution: Digital Research Infrastructure for the Arts and Humanities

Financial Geographical Scope: International

https://sigarra.up.pt/flup/pt/projectos_geral.mostra_projecto?P_ID=83065

Implementing Ethics by Design in AI: A Training Framework for the Healthcare Sector

Programme: Erasmus +

Funding Institution: COMISSÃO EUROPEIA

Financial Geographical Scope: International

https://sigarra.up.pt/flup/pt/projectos_geral.mostra_projecto?P_ID=81471

Learning from long-Term Care practices for the European Care Strategy

Programme: HE - Horizon Europe

Funding Institution: COMISSÃO EUROPEIA

Financial Geographical Scope: International

https://sigarra.up.pt/flup/pt/projectos_geral.mostra_projecto?P_ID=80477

Social Space and Nature Conservation in the Gerês-Xurés Transboundary Biosphere Reserve (Portugal/Spain)

Programme: Marie-Skłodowska-Curie Actions

Funding Institution: COMISSÃO EUROPEIA

	Financial Geographical Scope:International
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6. Additional ethics information

Not applicable

7. Additional information on security screening

Not applicable

8. Environmental considerations in light of the MSCA Green Charter

The ECO-CONNECT project fully aligns with the principles of the MSCA Green Charter by adopting sustainable research practices and minimizing its environmental footprint throughout the fellowship.

Low-Carbon Research Practices: The project will prioritize virtual participation in meetings, workshops, and conferences whenever possible, using digital platforms to reduce travel-related emissions. Essential travel will be planned efficiently, combining multiple activities into a single trip where feasible.

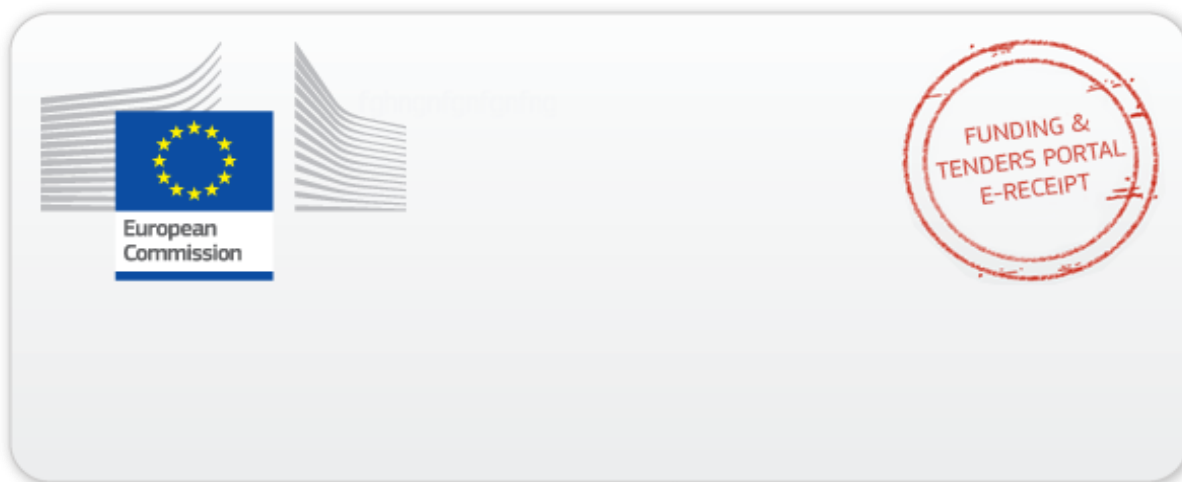
Sustainable Dissemination: All research outputs will be made openly available in digital form (e.g., institutional repositories, open-access journals), reducing reliance on printed materials. In order to sustainably reach a larger audience, public engagement initiatives (blogs, podcasts, and online lectures) will prioritize electronic means.

Institutional Support: The project's ecological responsibility is supported by UPORTO and CITCEM's ecologically conscious infrastructures, which include energy-efficient buildings, digital libraries, and recycling procedures.

Alignment of Content: The project's focus on ecology, postcoloniality, and interspecies interconnectedness which critically analyses the cultural dimensions of climate change and environmental consciousness, further demonstrates its commitment to sustainability.

9. Required for Global Fellowships only: Letter of commitment from the associated partner hosting the outgoing phase

Not applicable



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(<https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/portal/screen/support/faq>)